Worse was to come. At the holly barrier near Jagdalak, they came across hundreds of corpses impaled on the hedge, still slumped where they were shot down as they tried to claw their way over the thorns in the darkness. Just beyond that, within the low mud walls of the Jagdalak mud fort, they saw ‘skeletons thrown into heaps of eighty to one hundred’ where the column had halted for a day and two nights, exposed to the fire from the Ghilzais’ jezails on two sides, waiting in vain for Shelton and Elphinstone to return from their negotiations with Akbar Khan. ‘They were killed in ranks,’ wrote Seaton, ‘and in ranks we found them, the flesh still on their bodies, and every face perfectly recognisable to those by whom they were known.’ Near by, at the top of the valley, was a small round watchtower. Here they found the massed bodies of the hundreds of sepoys and camp followers whom the Afghans had captured, stripped of their clothes and driven out into the snow to die.

> The whole of the room was filled with skeletons and decaying bodies, up to the very roof; and there was a mound of them outside, half way up to the door, extending to a distance of twenty-seven feet from the wall, completely covering the steps. It was a ghastly sight. The poor fugitives appear to have crept in here for shelter, the last comers treading on and suffocating those who had preceded them, and then throwing out their bodies, only to be themselves served in the same way – trampled on, suffocated and thrown out by those that followed.
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> War carries in its train one pre-eminently dreadful evil – it engenders and nurses the spirit of revenge, stirs up all the malignant passions that lie dormant in man’s breast, and urges him to acts that are more suitable to a demon than to a being created in God’s image . . . Now the sepoys took vengeance wherever they could on the living, and if not on the living then on the dead.[50]

Any place believed to be associated with Akbar Khan came in for especially harsh treatment. One lovely village surrounded by orchards and gardens was thought by the troops to be one of the Wazir’s favourite summer residences, and despite surrendering without a fight, ‘every house was destroyed, every tree barked or cut down; after which the detatchment having collected a considerable spoil of bullocks, sheep, and goats, marched back to camp’.[51]

Nott’s progress was initially more disciplined and less violent than that of Pollock. But after several troops were killed in one village after the Ghilzai elders had formally surrendered, a full-scale massacre ensued: all males over puberty were bayoneted, the women were raped and their goods plundered. ‘Tears, supplications, were of no avail,’ wrote Neville